

Sari SPECTACLE

Sporting chunky jewellery, huge bindis and Kanjeevaram saris, a new breed of soapy superwomen has viewers hooked to their every move

TELLY HAPPY: The *Kyunki... parivaar* in its hey day



FAWZAN HUSAIN

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

The year was 2000. Amitabh Bachchan had been promoting his arrival on the small screen with *Kaun Banega Crorepati* (KBC). Slotted for prime time at 9 p.m., originally reserved for dance and drama, KBC was a gamble. It paid off, but somewhere amidst the KBC bombardment, the germs of a different show were being sown—a show that was born on the same day as KBC and changed entertainment forever. *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* was slated for 10.30 p.m. and was meant to hook viewers to the channel, according to Star Vice-President Prem Kamath.

Over 1,600 episodes later, the show, which gave birth to the term saas-bahu sagas, is still on air and has spawned an entire industry that feeds on glycerine, pancake and women who sleep in their Kanjeevarams. Along with TRPS, these sagas also rake in moolah by the truckload, in turn making television the highest tax paying industry.

The formula worked so well that within a year, Balaji Telefilms which till then was a mid-sized production house, with only a *Hum Paanch* to its hit list, had launched *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki*, *Kasautii Zindagi Kay*, *Kahiin Kissi Roz* and